

"Mr Watson, come here. I want you to see this!"

When asked to write this guest column, I was asked to predict where the mobile industry was going to be 10 years from now. Predicting this is akin to asking to guess if we'll have flying cars or if we'd have finally put a person on the surface of Mars, to be honest. In the last five years, the mobile technology space has evolved faster than the traditional computer industry has in the last 15. This is thanks to Apple, Google, Nokia, Facebook and countless others who've realised how important it is to invest time, resources and imagination into the mobile technology industry, I can now securely say that a person in Rural India with a smartphone has more access to immediate information, breaking news, multimedia content and over 600 million people (thanks to Facebook for being the King of Time Killers) than the Former American President Clinton did during his eight-year administration.

According to a recent report, there are around 5.5 billion mobile devices in the world. Of them, 2.3 are in the Asian/Pacific region alone. Emerging markets that didn't have internet four years ago are now awash with Android devices that are allowing people to finally communicate with the outside world without the need of trekking for miles to find an expensive cyber café. Mobile technology is finally uniting the planet into one cohesive group of bloggers, tweeters, photo and video creators and people just communicating with each other. Look what happened recently with the democratic upheaval in Egypt. Hundreds of thousands of people, fed up with their world, flooded the streets of their country and, with the help of their friends and their mobile phones, showed the world their struggle. "Social Media and Twitter/Facebook was the catalyst for the revolution" many said. It wasn't social

media that did it, it was the people. People who now have the technology to show the world what was immediately going on in their lives with the help of technology they didn't have 10 years ago.

Now, I know this was a long rambling to possibly answer the question posed to me – "Where is Mobile Technology going to be in 10 years?", but I have a point to all of this. It's not the technology that is going to be evolved, it's going to be what we do with it that is going to be evolved. When I first started out in the mobile industry a little over seven years ago, the most advanced mobile device was the Blackberry. Now, we have dual core (and some rumors of a quad core later next year) powered, GPS-enabled multimedia communication

devices that feel like a Playstation 3 and a modern desktop computer had a lovechild that I can put in my front pocket. Tablets of 10.1 inches, like the iPad and the flood of Android-powered tablets are eroding and killing off the ultra-portable netbooks just as Android-powered mobile phones have handed down the death sentence to the feature phones from only five years ago. But what does this mean to the kid in Rural India or the techie sitting in his garage in San Francisco?

Ten-inch Super AMOLED Screens with dual core processors connected to some sort of cloud-based server systems that allow me to access all of my music, videos and friends and whatever I want to know about on the internet at the touch of an icon is a nice thing, but it's just describing the tool that has taken a population of nearly seven billion people and moved them closer to each other. The technology has finally caught up to what the idea of mobility has always been – connecting people and information where ever they are and whatever it may be.

So, I'm sorry if this isn't exactly what you were expecting when it comes to a bit of technology crystal ball gazing of the future. But the truth is, the important thing to really keep in the back of your head isn't what's the new toy going to be in 2016 or what's going to be the new media service that some tech company that no one has heard of today is going to be rolling out on mobile devices in 2021...it's what we are going to do with it. For those of you who remember your history, when Alexander Bell first shouted "Watson, come here! I want to see you!", he set in motion the process of connecting the world. As the technology becomes more available, all of us will be connected...regardless of distance, gender, age, beliefs or interests. That is what I predict will be the world in 10 years. 



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Jason has been a pioneer in the Social Media and Mobile/Web 2.0 Industry for many years and frequently speaks about the future of Mobile Technology as it pertains to social interaction and is an up-and-coming futurist. He currently resides in San Francisco.